

Voter Guide

Waconia Patriot and Laker Pioneer's 2026 Election coverage

Biographical Details:

NAME: **Denny Laufenburger**

CITY OF RESIDENCE: Chanhassen, MN

OFFICE SOUGHT: **City Council Member**

EDUCATION: Bachelors in Marketing and MIS, University of Minnesota, Carlson School

OCCUPATION: US Navy Veteran; Retired from 40 years of Executive Leadership in Sales, Marketing & Public Relations in High Tech Computer industry. Currently active volunteer in School District 112 and Westwood Community Church, Legislative Salary Council as a Governor appointee, Leadership in Homeowners Association, and Minnesota Baseball Coaches Association Advisory Council.

Please limit responses to a maximum of 100 words for each numbered question.

Question 1: What prompted you seek election (or re-election) to office?

After serving in the City of Chanhassen government for 11 years including Council Member and Mayor, I felt it was time for me to continue my civic leadership. I'm healthy and live an active lifestyle that keeps me engaged in the city. I also feel that there are significant initiatives underway in the city that need to continue with proper guidance and not be derailed by advocates for change, for change sake!

Question 2: What is your long-term vision for the community?

I envision Chanhassen being a population of about 35,000 in the next 30 – 40 years. We will continue to be a community that values goodness in our churches, neighborhoods, schools and civic organizations. We will continue to prioritize the safety of our citizens and businesses. We will protect our green spaces, while managing commercial, industrial and residential development that contributes to the character of the community. We will continue to be an attraction for visitors to our community parks, our lakes and our landmark institutions; Chanhassen Dinner Theatre, Landscape Arboretum and Paisley Park.

Question 3: How do local governments meet resident and operating needs in the face of rising concerns about local property taxes and state/federal funding challenges?

It's a simple answer to a complex question. The costs of services that citizens want in the community are continuing to rise. You pay for these services from local taxes on commercial

and residential properties. You find a balance by either reducing the services that citizens want (which is a very unpopular position) or you increase property tax revenue from more development or from higher taxes on citizens and businesses. Somewhere, the prioritization of services needs to be addressed if the citizens truly want lower property taxes.

Question 4: What approach should local governments take toward the development of data centers, and what factors — such as economic development, tax revenue, infrastructure, energy and water use, land use and impacts on nearby residents — should guide decisions about future projects?

In addition to each of the factors that you mention, local government should learn from other municipal entities and the experiences they have had in both welcoming and prohibiting these data centers that are at the heart of the information technology, of which our citizens seem to have an insatiable appetite!

Question 5: What in your background/experience best qualifies you for office?

I'm the most experienced in city government, actively engaged in the community and as a retiree, I'm fully available to do the extensive work and research needed to understand and make good decisions on the issues. I represent a significant and growing population of the community. I know the importance of being able to listen to citizens, hear their legitimate concerns, and communicate and substantiate a position on the key issues of growth in our community.

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